



PLAYERS AT COURT

Elizabeth enjoyed watching plays, although she never visited the public playhouses. Instead, the players were commanded to give private performances for the court in the palaces around London. Before he became a playwright, Shakespeare would have been known to the queen as a player, from court performances.

PELICAN QUEEN

In this 1574 portrait by Nicholas Hilliard, the 41-year-old queen wears a brooch showing a pelican. Female pelicans were wrongly thought to feed their young on their own blood. The queen wore this brooch to show that she cared for her people with the self-sacrificing love of a perfect mother.

White pearls symbolized the queen's purity

Pelican drawing blood from its breast

Queen Elizabeth's court

WHEN THE QUEEN WAS NOT traveling the country, her court was based in the royal palaces around London, at Whitehall, Richmond, and Greenwich. Her royal barge carried her back and forth along the Thames River. Elizabeth surrounded herself with young male courtiers, who all competed for her favor. They flattered her by comparing her to the Roman moon goddess Diana, and called her "Gloriana," the glorious one. Londoners were fascinated by what Shakespeare called "court news"; in the play *King Lear*, "who loses and who wins, who's in, who's out."

BEAUTY SECRETS

The ladies at court used all kinds of concoctions to make lotions and face washes, which they believed would remove pimples, freckles, and other "blemishes" of the skin. Herbs, spices, and wine were popular ingredients, but many of the recipes were harmful to health, and even poisonous.

Cloves

Ginger

Nutmeg

Bay

Spices and herbs were used in anti-freckle recipes

Opal

Belladonna drops from the deadly nightshade plant made the eyes sparkle

Mercury

Lemon

Lemon juice and poisonous mercury were used in face washes